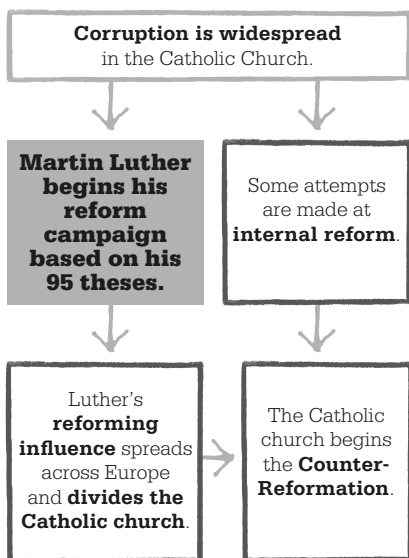


## Reform from within

Even before Luther wrote his 95 theses, a movement for reform had begun within the church. Inspired partly by Renaissance Humanism, it brought on a resurgence of scholarship and philosophy, and motivated churchmen such as Spaniard Francisco Ximenes, who produced a Bible with texts in Hebrew, Greek, Latin, and Aramaic. However, Luther's clear theological challenges prompted the papacy to prepare a more widely considered response. In 1545, Paul III called together the Council of Trent at which bishops and cardinals reaffirmed Catholic doctrines, from the importance of the priesthood and sacraments to the legitimacy of indulgences. But the council also introduced reforms: it forbade abuses such as the holding of multiple offices by one priest, set up training seminaries for priests, and, in an attempt to slow the spread of Protestant doctrine, established a commission to specify which books Catholics were forbidden to read. In addition, a number of popes from Paul III onward lived austerely, appointed like-minded bishops, and reviewed papal finances.



**The Ecstasy of Saint Teresa**, a white marble altarpiece and one of the masterpieces of High Roman Baroque, by Gian Lorenzo Bernini, the leading sculptor of his day.

## Counter-Reformation

The council met periodically for 18 years, and provoked a renewal and resurgence of Catholicism from within the church that is usually called the Counter-Reformation. The new Society of Jesus (also known as the order of Jesuits), founded by Spanish knight Ignatius Loyola in 1534, was approved by the pope in 1540 as an answer to the Reformation, and it spread a powerful Counter-Reformation message across Europe. The contemporary revival of Christian art, which coincided with the flowering of the baroque style in Italy, added a vibrant emphasis. Baroque churches were imposing and ornate, filled with affecting sculptures, paintings, and strikingly posed biblical scenes. This potent propaganda served to underline the difference between Catholic churches and their Protestant counterparts, which were usually plain and undecorated. Baroque art, together with the zeal of reforming popes and Jesuit priests, helped ensure that the Catholic church survived and flourished in countries such as Italy and Spain, even while the Protestant movement was gathering strength elsewhere. Europe, which had once been united under the pope in the Roman Catholic Church, was now irrevocably split into Catholic and Protestant states. The seeds were sown for over a century of conflict as subjects took up arms against their rulers, kings and princes clashed, and nations attacked nations in the name of religion. ■